

Session 8: God's Second Promise to Abram

Key Takeaways

- God's promise to make Avram's descendants "like the dust" evokes the creation of the human in Genesis 2.
- God's invitation for Avram to "walk about" the land carries on the theme of the righteous one walking in intimacy with God.
- God provides the land as an ark-like refuge of safety for Avram in the Eden hills while Lot chooses a false Eden down below, which will lead to ruin.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 13:12-18

¹² Avram dwelt in the land of Canaan,
and as for Lot, he dwelt in the cities of the valley ,
and he set up his tent by Sodom .
(¹³ Now, to Yahweh the men of Sodom were bad and moral-failures, very much .)

¹⁴ And Yahweh said to Avram,
after Lot separated from him,
a "Please lift up your eyes and see from the place where you are,
b to the north and to the south/Negev and to the east and to the west ,
a' ¹⁵ because all the land that you see ,
c to you I will give it , and to your seed , forever.
a ¹⁶ And I will make your seed like the dust of the land ,
b which, if one was able to count the dust of the land ,
a' then also your seed could be counted .
a ¹⁷ Arise , walk about in the land ,
b its length and its width ,
a' because to you I will give it ."

a ¹⁸ And Avram set up his tent ,
b and he went and dwelt by the oaks of Mamre ,
b' which are by Hebron ,
a' and he built there an altar to Yahweh.

Genesis 13:12-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Brothers Apart in Sodom and Hebron

Here Avram's sojourn into the land that began in [12:6](#) comes to completion when he finally settles in Hebron. The design of this unit highlights the contrast between the locations where Avram and Lot finally settle.

[Genesis 13:12-13](#) contrasts Avram's settlement in Canaan with Lot's settlement outside in the eastern valley of the Dead Sea, by Sodom. We recall from [13:10](#) that this valley is like Eden in Lot's eyes, but it turns out that this garden is full of bad seed. The two words used to describe Sodom echo the key words of the twin failures of the Eden story.

Genesis 13:13 Instructor's Translation

Now, to Yahweh the men of Sodom were **bad** (רע) and **moral-failures** (חטאים), very much.

- Adam and Eve fail at the tree of knowing good and **bad** (רע) because of the snake's deception (Gen. 3:6-7).
- Cain gives into the influence of "sin," that is, **moral failure** (חטאת) and murders his brother (Gen. 4:7).

In contrast, Avram dwells in a new Eden land, and the story concludes with him setting up his tent by the oak tree of Mamre near Hebron. Each element of this location's description ties into the larger symbolism of Eden, a place of tents, trees, divine visions.

Genesis 12:6-9

- Avram journeys through the land and camps near the oak of Moreh (אלון מורה) = "tree of seeing"

Genesis 12:10-13:11

- **12:10-20**
- **13:1-4**
- **13:5-11**

Genesis 13:18

- Avram settles in the land in his tent under the oaks of Mamre (אלני ממרא).

Genesis 12:6-13:18. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

A Promise Repeated and Expanded

God repeats his promises to Avram from 12:6 but expands both elements of seed and land.

Genesis 13:14-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁴ And Yahweh said to Avram,
after Lot separated from him,
“Please lift up your eyes and see from the place where you are,
to the north and to the south/Negev and to the east and to the west,
¹⁵ because all the land that you see,
to you I will give it, and to your seed, forever.
¹⁶ And I will make your seed like the dust of the land,
which, if one was able to count the dust of the land,
then also your seed could be counted.
¹⁷ Arise, walk about in the land,
its length and its width,
because to you I will give it.”

These promise expansions echo back to the divine blessings upon Adam and Noah, showing that Avram is the recipient of the Eden promise for all nations.

Seed of the New Humanity

Like humanity in Eden, God will create a seed for Avram that is “like” the innumerable dust of the land.

Genesis 13:16 Instructor’s Translation

And I will make your **seed** like the **dust of the land**, which, if one was able to count the dust of the land, then also your seed could be counted.

Genesis 2:7-8 Instructor’s Translation

⁷ then Yahweh *Elohim* formed the human from the **dust from the ground** ... ⁸ and Yahweh *Elohim* planted a garden in Eden, toward the east, and he placed there the human whom he had formed.

The Land as an Ark of Safety, Avram as a New Noah

God’s speech echoes the language of Noah right before the onset of the flood. He walks with God, so he is summoned to create a floating Eden so that he and the animals can live together in a place of refuge as the violence of humans is met by the powerful waters. The ark, like the land, has a length and width, which will provide safety for any inside.

Genesis 13:17 Instructor’s Translation

Arise, **walk about** (התהלך) in the land, **its length and its width** (לארכה ולרחבה) because to you I will give it.

Genesis 6:8-9 Instructor’s Translation

⁸ But Noah found favor in the eyes of Yahweh. ⁹ These are the birth-generations of Noah; Noah was a righteous one, blameless in his generation; Noah **walked about** (התהלך) with *Elohim*;

Genesis 6:13-15 Instructor’s Translation

13 And *Elohim* said to Noah,
 “The end of all flesh has come before me, because the land is filled with violence because of them, and behold, I am going to cause ruin with the land.

14 Make for yourself an ark of gopher trees;
 you will make the ark with nests,
 and shall pitch it inside and out with pitch.

15 This is how you will make it:

- 300 cubits: **the length** (אֵרֶךְ) of the ark
- 50 cubits: **its width** (רָחֵבָה)
- 30 cubits: its height.”

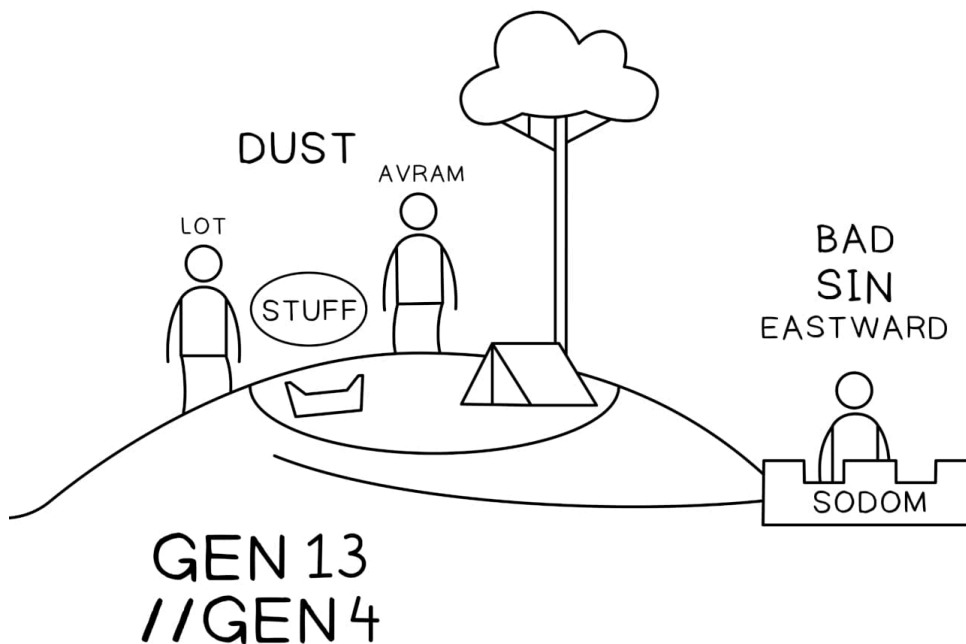
Genesis 12-13 as Replay of Genesis 2-6

Genesis 2 • God’s blessing of fruitful seed • Garden abundance • Sacred space of God’s presence by the tree of life on Mt. Eden	Genesis 3 • Foolish failure at the tree of testing that is “good of sight” • Deception and lack of trust in God’s word • Exile from Eden	Genesis 4-6 • Brothers with abundance • Jealousy and conflict • Brothers “separate” through violence • Non-chosen brother settles in the east, where violence is simmering, leading to a flood of judgment	Violence and Flood!
Genesis 12:1-9 • God's blessing of abundance and protection • Promise of fruitful seed • God's presence at tree and mountains	Genesis 12:10-20 • Foolish failure with Sarai who is "beautiful of sight" • Deception and lack of trust in God's word • Exile from false-Eden (i.e., Egypt)	Genesis 13 • Brother with abundance • Jealousy and conflict • Brothers separate through non-violence! • Non-chosen brother settles in the east, where violence is simmering, leading up to a flood of judgment	Violence and Flood!
Genesis 12-13 as Replay of Genesis 2-6. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).			

In both sequences, God appoints a chosen figure to receive divine blessing and to become a conduit of that blessing to others. Both figures fail in acts of folly that are rooted in a lack of trust in God’s wisdom and word.

Exile results in both cases, though the pattern is more sophisticated with Avram: He first undergoes a self-imposed exile from Canaan and then is exiled from Egypt by Pharaoh. It's only in Genesis 13 that Avram breaks that pattern. Once the conflict with Lot begins, Avram becomes a mediator for peace and avoids a violent conflict between brothers. Lot ends up choosing a place that is similar to Cain's city, a realm of violence (Lemek in Gen. 4:18-24; the violent warriors of Gen. 6:4; the wicked and violent men of Sodom in Gen. 13:13 and 14:1-10).

Avram's Hilltop Refuge



Avram's Hilltop Refuge. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

What themes and key words in Genesis 13:14-20 recall the mountaintop garden of Eden? How have these themes been developed in Genesis 1-11?

Session 9: A Flood of Violence

Key Takeaways

- The kings of Genesis 14:1-10 are portrayed as personifications of evil and corruption through their names and other symbolism.
- The kings eliminated the groups of giants, recalling the Nephillim whose violence ruined the land and brought on the flood.
- Avram's dramatic rescue of Lot is depicted as miraculous, validating Avram's status as God's chosen agent.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 14:1-16

a ¹ And it came about in the days of **Amraphel**, **king** of **Shinar**,
b of **Aryok**, **king** of **Elasar**,
c of **Kedorlaomer**, **king** of **Elam**,
d and of **Tidal**, **king** of Goyyim (= "nations"),
a ² that **they made war** with **Bera** (= "in evil"), **king** of **Sodom**,
a' and with **Birsha** (= "in wickedness"), **king** of **Gomorrah**,
b and with **Shinab** (= "father hater"), **king** of **Admah**,
b' and with **Shemeved** (= "name of destruction"), **king** of **Tsiboyim**,
c and with **the king** of **Bela** (= "devour") [this is Zoar].
³ **All of these joined together** in the **valley of Siddim** [this is the Sea of Salt]

a ⁴ For **twelve years** they had been slaves of **Kedorlaomer**,
a' and in the **thirteenth year** they rebelled,
b ⁵ and in the **fourteenth year** **Kedorlaomer** **went**,
b' and the kings who were with him,
a and **they struck** the **Rephaim** in Ashteroth-Qarnayim (= "Asherah of Twin-Peaks")
a' and the **Zuzim** in Ham,
a" and the **Emim** in Shaveh-Qiryathayim (= "the Plain of Twin-Cities"),
b ⁶ and the **Horites** in the mountains of Seir,
b' unto the Oak of Paran which is by the wilderness.
c ⁷ And they returned and **they went** to Eyn-Mishpat (= "the Spring of Judgment") [this is Qadesh]
and **they struck** all the field of the **Amalekites**,

c' and also the **Amorites** who dwell in Hatzetzon-Tamar (= "Heap of Palms")

- a 8 And **the king of Sodom** went out,
b and **the king of Gomorrah** ,
b and **the king of Admah** ,
b and **the king of Tsiboyim** ,
b and the king **of Bela** [this is Zoar]
a' and they **lined themselves up for war** in the **valley of Siddim** ,
a 9 against **Kedorlaomer, king of Elam** ,
b and **Tidal, king of Goyyim**
b and **Amraphel, king of Shinar** ,
b and **Aryok, king of Elasar** .
c Four kings against five.
a 10 Now, the **valley of Siddim** was full of **many pits** of tar.
b And **they fled** ,
c **the king of Sodom, and Gomorrah** ,
b' and **they fell** into there.
a And those **remaining** fled to the **mountains** .

- 11 **And they took**
all the **possessions** of **Sodom and Gomorrah** ,
and all their **food** ,
and **they went away** .
12 And **they took**
Lot and his **possessions** ,
the son of the **brother** of Avram,
and **they went away** .
Now, he was dwelling in Sodom .

- a 13 And a **refugee** came and **reported to Avram the Hebrew** .
b **Now, he was dwelling among the oaks of Mamre** the Amorite,
b the **brother** of Eshkol, and the **brother** of Aner.
b Now, they **were members of a covenant** with Avram.
a' 14 And **Avram heard that his brother** had been taken **captive** .

- a And he brought out **his trained men** ,
b **those born of his house** ,
b' three hundred and eighteen,
a' **and he chased them** unto Dan.

- a 15 And **he divided himself against them** by night,
 b **he and his servants**
 a' and **he struck them**,
 a'' **and he chased them** unto Khobah, which is north of Damascus,
 a 16 and he returned all the **possessions**,
 a' and also **Lot** his **brother** and his **possessions** he returned,
 b and also the women and the people.

Genesis 14:1-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Of Kings and Giants

The story highlights these repeated lists of kings. The lists are arranged in symmetrical patterns, and the names of the kings are loaded with sarcastic wordplays.

Mesopotamian Kings: 1st List	Mesopotamian Kings: 2nd List
A Amraphel, king of Shinar B Aryok, king of Elasar C Kedorlaomer, king of Elam D Tidal, king of Goyyim	C Kedorlaomer, king of Elam D Tidal, king of Goyyim A Amraphel, king of Shinar B Aryok, king of Elasar
Canaanite Kings: 1st List	Canaanite Kings: 2nd List
A Bera, king of Sodom B Birsha, king of Gomorrah C Shinab, king of Admah D Shemeved, king of Tsiboyim E The king of Bela [this is Zoar]	A The king of Sodom, B The king of Gomorrah C The king of Admah D The king of Tsiboyim E The king of Bela [this is Zoar]

Mesopotamian and Canaanite Kings Lists. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The list of nine kings is repeated two times, but not identically. The order of the four Mesopotamian kings is inverted so that the king of Shinar is number one in the first list, and the king of Elam is number one in the second list.

This seemingly random variation becomes meaningful when the story is mapped out in its literary sequence.

A - Amraphel, king of Shinar
B - Aryok, king of Elasar

C - Kedorlaomer, king of Elam
D - Tidal, king of Goyim

A - Bera king of Sodom
B - Birsha, king of Gomorrah
C - Shinav, king of Admah
D - Shemeved, king of Tsevoyim
E - the king of Bela [this is Zoar]

Kedorlaomer and the Kings With Him Strike the Giant Clans

- Rephaim / Zuzim / Emim
- Horites / Amalekites / Amorites

A - the king of Sodom
B - the king of Gomorrah
C - the king of Admah
D - the king of Tsevoyim
E - the king of Bela [this is Zoar]

C - Kedorlaomer, king of Elam
D - Tidal, king of Goyim

A - Amraphel, king of Shinar
B - Aryok, king of Elasar

Genesis 14:1-10 Kings. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The names have been listed in symmetrical pattern, which places the Mesopotamian kings at the outer locations and highlights the giant clans in the center position. Each of these design features seems intentional and communicates something significant.

The inverted Mesopotamian kings: The two kings highlighted are the rulers of Shinar and Elam. Both kingdoms play a significant role in the larger biblical story.

Shinar

Shinar was last mentioned in [Genesis 11:1-2](#), in the genealogy of Ham, son of Noah: "And all the land ... journeyed east and found a plain in the land of Shinar and they settled there" and began building Babylon.

Shinar is a rare term used to describe the flood plain in which Babylon and its ziggurats were built. Every time it appears in the Hebrew Bible, it is ominous:

- "The beginning of Nimrod's kingdom was Babylon ... in the land of Shinar" ([Gen. 10:10](#))
- "On that day, Yahweh will a second time with his arm restore the remnant of his people from Assyria, Egypt ... Elam, Shinar ... and from the islands of the sea." ([Isaiah 11:11](#))
- "[Nebuchadnezzar] brought the vessels of the temple of *Elohim* to the land of Shinar, into the treasury of his *elohim*." ([Daniel 1:2](#))

Elam

"Elam" is the Hebrew word for "Persia," and was last mentioned in the genealogy of Shem, son of Noah: "The sons of Shem: Elam, Ashur, Arphaxad, Lud, and Aram" ([Gen. 10:22](#)).

Interestingly, Elam/Persia is the nation that topples Babylon and becomes the instrument of God to restore the exiled Israelites back to the promised land (see [Ezra 1:1-11](#)).

Later, the king of Babylon (descendant of Ham) will exile Avram's descendants to the land of Shinar, and Elam (son of Shem) is the nation that will restore those exiles back to their homeland.

The list of Canaanite kings is repeated identically, and most of the names come from the genealogy of Ham in Genesis 10.

Genesis 10:6, 19 NASB

⁶ The sons of Ham were Cush and Mizraim and Put and Canaan. ... ¹⁹ The territory of the Canaanite extended from Sidon as you go toward Gerar, as far as Gaza; as you go toward **Sodom** and **Gomorrah** and **Admah** and **Zeboim**, as far as Lasha.

This precise linking of the kings to the list of Noah's sons in Genesis 10 is intentional. The author is trying to show that this battle is an outworking of the sibling rivalry that Noah anticipated in Genesis 9:25-26.

Genesis 9:24-26 NIV

²⁴ When Noah awoke from his wine and found out what his youngest son had done to him, ²⁵ he said, "Cursed be Canaan!
The lowest of **slaves**
will he be to his brothers."
²⁶ He also said,
"Praise be to the LORD, the God of Shem!
May Canaan be the **slave** of Shem."

Genesis 14:4-5 Instructor's Translation

⁴ For twelve years [the sons of Ham] had been **slaves** of Kedorlaomer, and in the thirteenth year they rebelled, ⁵ and in the fourteenth year Kedorlaomer came, and the kings who were with him [sons of Shem]

The Mesopotamian Kings Versus the Giants

The eastern kings come to Canaan and strike the giant clans associated with the Nephilim, the giant warriors from the time of the flood.

Rephaim in Ashteroth Qarnaim

The Rephaim were a clan of giants, with a king named Og who ruled in Ashteroth, in the region of Bashan on the east side of the Jordan River.

Deuteronomy 3:8-11 ESV

⁸ So we took the land at that time out of the hand of the two kings of the Amorites who were beyond the Jordan, from the Valley of the Arnon to Mount Hermon ... ¹⁰ all the cities of the tableland and all Gilead and all Bashan ... cities of the kingdom of Og in Bashan. ¹¹ (For only Og the king of Bashan was left of the remnant of the Rephaim. Behold, his bed was a bed of iron. Is it not in Rabbah of the Ammonites? Nine cubits was its length, and four cubits its breadth, according to the common cubit.)

Joshua 13:12 ESV

all the kingdom of Og in Bashan, who reigned in Ashtaroth and in Edrei (he alone was left of the remnant of the Rephaim); these Moses had struck and driven out.

The Greek Septuagint translators of Genesis rendered the Rephaim of [Genesis 14:5](#) with the Greek word *gigantas* (γίγαντας) = “giants,” the same word they use to translate “Nephilim” in [Genesis 6:4](#).

The Zuzim (זוזים) in Ham

The Zuzim, also known as the “Zamzummim” (זמזומים), lived in the region later inhabited by the Ammonites, who were actually part of the Rephaim giant clans.

Deuteronomy 2:19-21 ESV

¹⁹ ... I will not give you any of the land of the people of Ammon as a possession ... ²⁰ It is also counted as a land of Rephaim. Rephaim formerly lived there—but the Ammonites call them Zamzummim— ²¹ a people great and many, and **tall as the Anakim**; but the LORD destroyed them before the Ammonites, and they dispossessed them and settled in their place

The Emim in Shaveh-Qiryataim

The Emim were also actually part of the Rephaim giant clans.

Deuteronomy 2:10-11 ESV

¹⁰ The Emim formerly lived there, a people great and many, and tall as the Anakim. ¹¹ **Like the Anakim** they are also counted as Rephaim, but the Moabites call them Emim.

All of these tribes are connected to the Anakim and the Nephilim from the time of the flood.

Numbers 13:27-33 ESV

²⁷ And they told him, "We came to the land to which you sent us. It flows with milk and honey, and this is its fruit. ²⁸ However, the people who dwell in the land are strong, and the cities are fortified and very large. And besides, we saw the descendants of Anak there. ²⁹ The Amalekites dwell in the land of the Negeb. The Hittites, the Jebusites, and the Amorites dwell in the hill country. And the Canaanites dwell by the sea, and along the Jordan." ... ³² "The land, through which we have gone to spy it out, is a land that devours its inhabitants, and all the people that we saw in it are of great height. ³³ And there we saw the Nephilim (the sons of Anak, who come from the Nephilim), and we seemed to ourselves like grasshoppers, and so we seemed to them."

This entire list of the inhabitants of Canaan and the Transjordan provides an accounting for all the regions that the Israelites will later enter in Numbers 20 onward. These regions were filled with earlier inhabitants, clans of giants who were dealt with by God's providential justice long before Israel entered into the land.

Deuteronomy 2:9-11, 18-23 ESV

⁹ And the LORD said to me, "Do not harass Moab or contend with them in battle, for I will not give you any of their land for a possession, because I have given Ar to the people of Lot for a possession." ¹⁰(The **Emim** formerly lived there, **a people great and many, and tall as the Anakim**. ¹¹Like the **Anakim** they are also counted as **Rephaim**, but the Moabites call them **Emim**. ¹²The **Horites** also lived in **Seir** formerly, but the people of Esau dispossessed them and destroyed them from before them and settled in their place, as Israel did to the land of their possession, which the LORD gave to them.)

¹⁸"Today you are to cross the border of Moab at Ar. ¹⁹And when you approach the territory of the people of Ammon, do not harass them or contend with them, for I will not give you any of the land of the people of Ammon as a possession, because I have given it to the sons of Lot for a possession." ²⁰(It is also counted as a land of **Rephaim**. **Rephaim** formerly lived there—but the Ammonites call them **Zamzummim**— ²¹**a people great and many, and tall as the Anakim**; but the LORD destroyed them before the Ammonites, and they dispossessed them and settled in their place, ²²as he did for the people of Esau, who live in Seir, when he destroyed the Horites before them and they dispossessed them and settled in their place even to this day. ²³As for the Avvim, who lived in villages as far as Gaza, the Caphtorim, who came from Caphtor, destroyed them and settled in their place.)

Moses' speech in Deuteronomy 2 assumes a backstory of God's judgment on the giant clans on the east side of the Jordan, and Genesis 14 supplies that narrative. The point of Moses' speech is that just as God providentially gave other lands to the non-chosen descendants and relatives of Avraham (Lot or Esau), so also he will use the Israelites to dispossess the Canaanites. Genesis 14 provides the providential backstory, implying that God used the eastern kings led by Babylon as a divine instrument of judgment on the giant clans of Canaan and Transjordan. However, because of Babylon's over-assertion in the capturing of Lot, the seed of Avraham, God then delivers the coalition over to Avraham.

This chapter, then, makes Avram the superior to the eastern kings, the Canaanites, and all the giants of the ancient time. It also qualifies Avram to be the true inheritor of these very lands, because he was their deliverer.

This all seems aligned with a strategy that sets the returnees from exile on analogy with Avraham. They too (re)entered “Canaan” (= Persian *Yehud*) after God had used Babylon to judge the previous inhabitants (the Israelites and Judean kingdoms along with the non-Israelite population), and found themselves called to inherit it according to God’s promise.

A Flood of Violence

Recall that Genesis 11-14 retraces the thematic sequence of Genesis 1-9, and Genesis 14 comes at the precisely the moment we are expecting a flood/re-creation moment. The story is filled with unique connections to the onset of the flood narrative.

Genesis 6-8	Genesis 14:1-24
The mighty violent warriors (Heb. <i>gibborim</i>), also called “Nephilim, men of the name” (notice the prominence of names in this chapter) spill much blood on the land, filling it with violence. Gen. 6:4 The Nephilim were on the earth in those days, and also afterward, when the sons of God came in to the daughters of men, and they bore children to them. Those were the mighty men who were of old, men of the name. Gen. 6:13 Then God said to Noah, “The end of all flesh has come before me; for the earth is filled with violence because of them; and behold, I am about to cause their ruin them with the land. The flood-waters are called “mighty and strong” (Heb. <i>gavar</i>, גבר), from the same root as “mighty warrior” (Heb. <i>gibbor</i>, גבור). Gen. 7:18-20 ¹⁸ The water was mighty (Heb. <i>gavar</i>, גבר) and increased greatly upon the land ...	• The Mesopotamian kings strike the Rephaim and other giant clans (Gen. 14:5, LXX γιγαντας), connected to the Anakim (Deut. 2:10-11, 3:11-13) and the Nephilim (Num. 13:33). • The Mesopotamian kings become a flood of divine judgment that consists of warriors (<i>gibborim</i>) sweeping through the land promised to Avram, clearing out its previous inhabitants.
<i>Mesopotamian Kings As a Flood of Violence.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).	

Genesis 6-8

Genesis 14:1-24

¹⁹The water was **mighty** (Heb. *gavar*, גבר), very very much upon the land, and all the high hills under the skies were covered.
²⁰The water was **mighty** (Heb. *gavar*, גבר) fifteen cubits higher, and the mountains were covered.

Gen. 7:11 The flood happens as the “fountains of the deep abyss” split open, and the “windows” (Heb. *‘arubbot*, ארבת) open up.

Gen. 11:3 The tower and city of Babylon, which were scattered in a flood-like judgment, were built by “tar” (חמר) used as mortar.

After the flood, Noah and his family are a remnant (נשאר/שאר), and they escape and are placed upon the “mountains of Ararat.”

Gen. 7:23 “Only Noah, together with those with him in the ark, was left remaining (נשאר).”

Gen. 8:4 “In the seventh month ... the ark rested upon the mountains (הר) of Ararat”

Gen. 8:21 After the flood, God refers to the waters as a “strike” upon the land (נכה) — “I will never again **strike** (נכה) the land as I have done.

God makes a covenant promise to Noah, that he will provide a refuge for him and his family in the ark built of trees (עץ), where he can live in safety with the animals and plenty of food.

Gen. 6:14 “Make for yourself an ark of gopher trees (עץ) ...

Gen. 6:18-19 “But I will set up my covenant (ברית) with you and so you will enter the ark, you and

The kings of Sodom and Gomorrah fall into pits of pitch.

Gen. 14:10 Now, the valley of Siddim has pits, pits (בארות בארת) of tar (חמר).

After the flood-like attack of the kings, the survivors flee to the mountains.

Gen. 14:10 ... and those left remaining fled to the mountains (הר).

The Mesopotamian kings come and “strike” (נכה) the giant clans.

Gen. 14:5, 7 Khedorlaomer came ... and **struck** (נכה) the Rephaim ... and they **struck** (נכה) the field of the Amalekites.

Gen. 14:13 While the battle rages around Avram, he sits in peace among the oak trees of Mamre.

Gen. 14:13 While corrupt Canaanites are being struck all around, a group of Canaanites who are in a covenant (ברית) with Avram, sitting with him, are perfectly safe

Gen. 14:11-12 The Mesopotamian kings come and

Mesopotamian Kings As a Flood of Violence. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Genesis 6-8	Genesis 14:1-24
your sons and your wives and your sons wives and every living thing of all flesh ... in order to keep them alive with you.” Gen. 6:21 “And take (לקח) for yourself food (מאכל) that you will eat (אכל) and gather it for yourself.”	“take” (לקח) both the “food” (אכל) and Lot from Sodom.
Gen. 5:21, 28-29 Noah is the great-grandson of Enoch (חנוך) Gen. 5:29 Noah (נח) ... “this one will comfort us (ינחמנו) us” Gen. 6:8 But Noah (נח) found favor (חן) in the eyes of Yahweh	Gen. 14:14 Avram prepares his “dedicated men” (חנכי).
<i>Mesopotamian Kings As a Flood of Violence. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>	

These hyperlinks establish Avram, the seed of Noah, as a new Noah who is delivered from the Mesopotamian kings’ flood of violence and who becomes the agent of God’s deliverance and judgment.

Avram is the agent of God’s deliverance because the Canaanites who are in a covenant with him are delivered and safe from the Mesopotamian attack.

Avram is the agent of God’s judgment because he and the Canaanites with him strike back against the Mesopotamian kings, overcoming them and rescuing the captives of Sodom.

In this story, the cursed Canaanites are struck by wicked kings of the east, who are depicted as a flood of wickedness. While God’s providence is not explicitly evoked, it does appear to be a judgment on the Canaanites, who, by extension from Sodom and Gomorrah’s “great evil and sin” ([Gen. 13:13](#)), deserve divine justice. But, in contrast to the flood, the violent kings of the east come led by Babylon. This prepares us for the portrait of Babylon as God’s “servant” in [Jeremiah 25](#), who will be used for a time (paralleling [Gen. 14:1-10](#)) until he oversteps his bounds (paralleling [Gen. 14:11-24](#)) and becomes the object of God’s judgment instead of its instrument.

Avram the Hebrew and His Covenant With the Canaanites

The Canaanites are portrayed in two ways.

1. The Canaanites unconnected to Avram are swept away in the battle of the kings who come, strike, and return. Their “wicked” status is indicated by the names of the kings: “In Evil,” “In Wickedness,” “Father

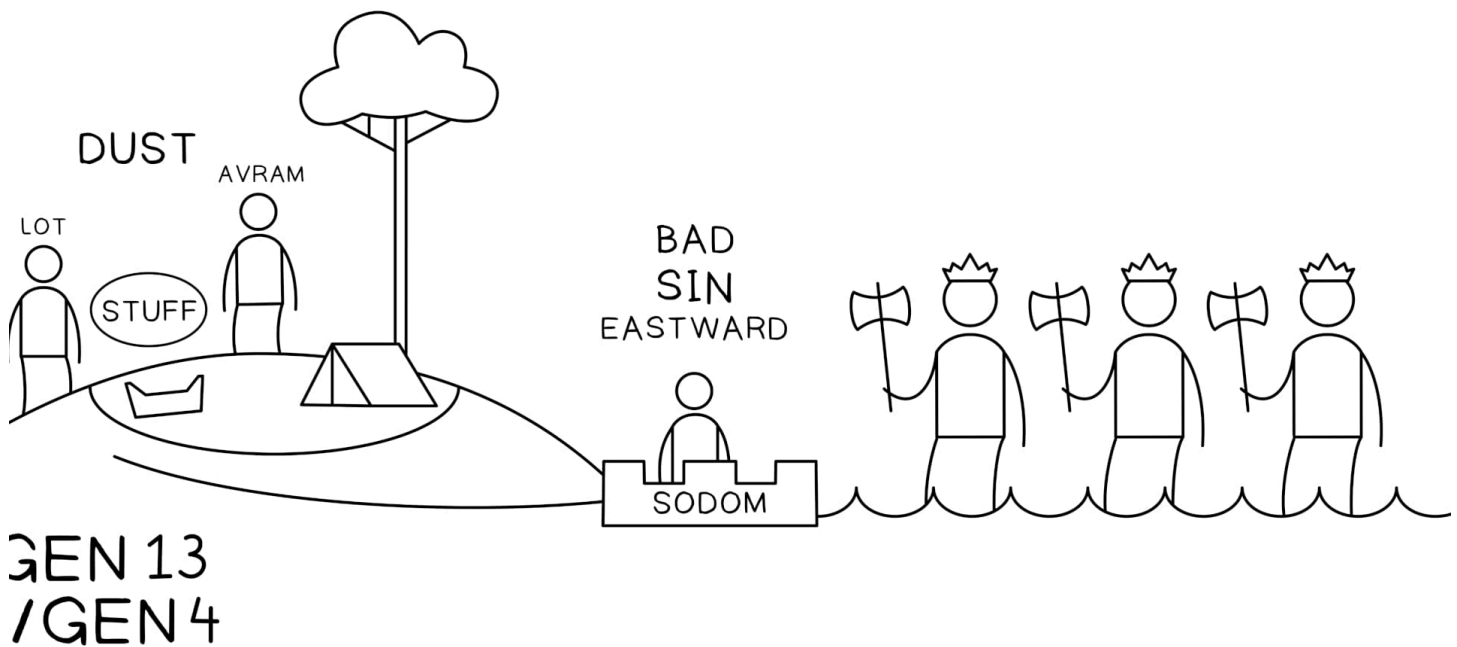
Hater," "Name of Destruction," and "Devoured." These are the Canaanites associated with Avram and Lot.

2. The good Canaanites (Mamre, Aner, Eshkol) hanging out with Avram in his mini-Eden are associated with Avram by covenant. Not only are they spared, but they go with Avram and defeat the violent nations themselves, chasing them all the way "unto Dan" (עד דן), which sounds like the Hebrew for "unto Eden." Note that Eshkol (אשכול) means "Grape Cluster," which is a garden image.

Avram the Commando King-Slayer

This portrait of Avram as the guerrilla warrior is unique in the Avram stories because he is usually peaceable and non-violent in his relationships with the Canaanites. His fighting force of 318 is an odd detail, explained by its relation to Eliezer in the next story.

A Flood of Warrior Kings



Flood of Warrior Kings. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

How do the violent kings of Genesis 14 replay the flood theme? How does this help us understand the importance of this episode in Avram's story?

Session 10: Melchizedek the Royal Priest

Key Takeaways

- This narrative offers us the first picture of Avram's transformation as he more faithfully reflects God's image.
- The kings of Salem and Sodom stand in stark contrast to one another. The king of Salem comes with feast and blessing, whereas the king of Sodom comes to take.
- Biblical authors hold up Melchizedek as an ideal, untainted royal priest.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 14:17-24

a 17 And **the king of Sodom** **went out to meet him**,
b after he returned from **striking** Kedorlaomer, and the kings with him,
a' into the valley of the plain [this is the valley of the king].

18 Now (just then), **Melchizedek, king of Shalem**, **brought out bread and wine**.
A Now, he was the **priest** of **El-Most High**
19 And he **blessed** him, and he said:
May Avram be **blessed** by **El-Most High**,
B the **possessor of skies and land**.
20 And may **El-Most High** be **blessed**,
who has delivered your adversaries into your hand.
A **And he gave to him** (נתן) **a tenth** (עשר) **of everything**.

21 And **the king of Sodom** **said to Avram**,
A **"Give to me** (נתן) **the people**,
and the possessions, **take** (לקח) **for yourself**."

22 And **Avram said to the king of Sodom**,
"I lift up my hand to Yahweh, **El-Most High**,
possessor of skies and land:
B 23 Not from a strap or sole of a sandal
will I **take** (לקח) from all that is yours,
so that you can't say,

'I made Avram **wealthy** (עשר)!'!

a 24 Only what the **young men** have eaten,

A b and **the portion** (חלק) of the men who went with me,

a' **Aner, Eshkol, and Mamre,**

b' they can **take** (לקח) their **portion** (חלק)."

Genesis 14:1-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

A Tale of Two Kings

This story needs to be understood from multiple perspectives, like a concentric circle with each layer moving outward and getting larger: Genesis 14:17-24 within Genesis 14:1-24, within 11:27-14:24, within 11:27-25:18, within Genesis as a whole, within the Torah as a whole, and in relationship to the Prophets and Writings.

With Melchizedek, we come to the 10th king in the story! In contrast to the king of Sodom, whose name is "Evil" (ברע), we now have the "King of Righteousness" (מלכי־צדק)! The contrast in their names symbolizes their characters and what they want for or from Avram.

Bera King of Sodom

- Sodom / Evil
- He demands that Avram give (נתן) him the war captives, but Avram can take (לקח) the plunder.
- He wants to have Avram in his debt by making him wealthy (עשר).

Mekhizedeq King-Priest of Salem

- Salem (= Jerusalem) / Righteousness
- He offers food and blessing to Avram and demands nothing in return.
- He gives generously to Avram, so Avram happily gives (נתן) one-tenth (מעשר) as a gift in return.

Bera and Melchizedek represent two ways that the rulers of nations relate to God's chosen one, who was selected to be the conduit of God's blessing to the nations. Recall God's promise to Avram in Genesis 12:3.

Genesis 12:3 Instructor's Translation

Those who bless you will be blessed,
those who treat you as insignificant will be cursed
and through you, all the families of the land will find blessing.

"It is perfectly natural that a returning hero, whose victory has also benefited the entire region, should be officially greeted by a distinguished personage. But the intrusive nature of the report here, interrupting the smooth sequence of verses 17 and 21, is obvious, and was noted by Rashi, Abravanel, and Hizkuni. Its position, which is original and not a later insertion, heightens the tension produced by the sudden appearance of the king of Sodom, whose very name is redolent of evil. It also transforms into a spiritual experience what was up to now a secular incident. Victory in war is not attributed to Abram's skill and valor but to the will of God, who is the ultimate arbiter of human destiny. It is inconceivable that the biblical

Narrator would not have introduced such a note into the story. The artfulness with which the Melchizedek episode is integrated into the narrative is proven by the priest-king's mention of Abram's victory and by reference to the 'Valley of the King' (v. 17), which smooths the way for the appearance of the 'king of Salem,' the first element of whose name—Melchizedek—also means 'king.' There is a subtle contrast in the uses of the verb *y-ts-*, 'to go out.' The king of Sodom 'came out' empty-handed to meet his benefactor, and the first word he uttered was 'give!' The king of Salem 'brought out' bread and wine and offered a blessing, even though he may have come to collect his tithe. The name of Melchizedek's city—Salem (Heb. *shalem*)—is suggestive of shalom, the peace that Abram's intervention brought to the region. Finally, the extraordinary title of God used by Abram in his colloquy with the king of Sodom is the name just used twice by Melchizedek."

Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [*The JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 109.

A Royal Priest Who Blesses the Blessed One

Melchizedek is the first explicit "royal priest" in the book of Genesis. Adam and Eve are implicitly royal priests, but Melchizedek is clearly a royal priest, and not from the line of Seth, Noah, or Shem (or at least, not in the text).

He rules Salem (lit. *shalem* / שָׁלֵם), which later in the Hebrew Bible is identified as JeruSALEM (see [Ps. 76:1-2](#), where "God's tent is in Salem, his dwelling is in Zion"). It will later be called "Jebus" when it is in the possession of the Canaanites ([Josh. 18:28](#); [Judg. 19:10-11](#); [2 Sam. 5:6-7](#)).

Melchizedek pronounces a blessing on Avraham in the name of El-Elyon, the creator/possessor of skies and land. This divine title, and Avraham's statement in [14:22](#) that El-Elyon is Yahweh, links Melchizedek's God to "Yahweh *Elohim*" of [Genesis 1-2](#). He is a genuine priest of the God of Israel, but before Israel ever existed, and before Yahweh was known by that name (see [Exod. 3:12-15](#)). This connects him to the line of genuine worship that stems back to Seth in [Genesis 4:26](#).

Melchizedek's blessing on Avram links back to God's promise in [Genesis 12:1-3](#). Thus, we can expect that Melchizedek and the city he rules will experience God's blessing some time in the future.

Genesis 14:19-20 NASB

¹⁹ He **blessed** him and said,
"Blessed be Abram of God Most High,
possessor of heaven and earth;
²⁰ And **blessed be God Most High**,
who has delivered your enemies into your hand."
And he gave him a tenth of all.

Genesis 12:2-3 NASB

² And I will make you a great nation,
and I will **bless** you,
and make your name great;
and so you shall be a **blessing**;
³ and **I will bless those who bless you**,

and the one who curses you I will curse.
And in you all the families of the earth will be **blessed**.

Notice how Melchizedek's blessing develops God's own blessing on Avram. God has promised seed and land, and now Melchizedek adds deliverance from enemies. God will bless Avram with abundant descendants and a promised land, and he will deliver Avram's descendants from their enemies.

God's Promise of Blessing

An important theme at work in Genesis 14 is the blessing of God upon Avram, and how the various characters in the story relate to Avram.

Genesis 14:13-14 NASB*

¹³ Then a fugitive came and told Abram the Hebrew. Now, he was living by the oaks of **Mamre the Amorite, brother of Eshcol and brother of Aner, and these were in a covenant with Abram.**

¹⁴ When Abram heard that his relative had been taken captive, he led out his trained men, born in his house, three hundred and eighteen, and went in pursuit as far as Dan.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

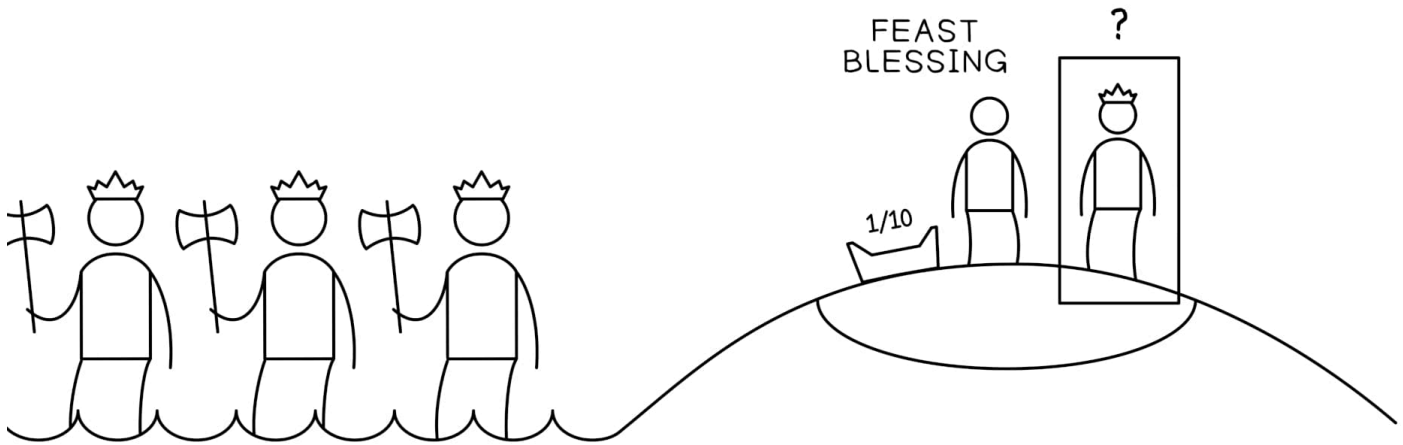
These Amorites who had made a covenant with Avram, God's chosen one, experienced the blessing of God's protection and also shared in the victory of Avram. In contrast, the gentile kings who oppose God's chosen one are defeated despite the odds in their favor. This contrast bears an important message: God's blessing upon Avram can be experienced by the nations if they relate peaceably with God's chosen one, like Mamre and his crew, or like Melchizedek.

Genesis 14 shows the outworking of God's promise in Genesis 12:2-3. Avram becomes a blessing to the nations as he fights against violent, pagan kings and rescues the innocent. And those who "cursed" him (by kidnapping his nephew) find themselves cursed.

Melchizedek blesses Avram, and so we expect God will bless Melchizedek in return. The payment of a tithe to Melchizedek shows that Avram honors him as a superior. The sudden introduction and disappearance of Melchizedek leaves a great impression on the reader.

The reader is unsurprised when, much later in the story, David is made king of Israel and establishes this same city as Israel's sacred capitol. David moves the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem and assumes the role of a royal priest just like Melchizedek! See 2 Samuel 5-8.

Avram and Melchizedek



Avram and Melchizedek. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

How does Genesis 14:17-24 begin to demonstrate a transformation in Avram's character?